

A Cool Start

Young boys from the fringes of society in Bangalore learn to manage a modern ice-cream and juice parlour and help others from its profits

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BANGALORE

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SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN

THE BOYS AT THEIR PARLOUR

| By Stephen David |

When 19-year-old Majid was dumped in a Bangalore remand home two years ago he did not know the difference between a milk shake and a policeman's shake-up. Another teenager Rajesh was slogging it out in a brick-kiln at the same time while Lawrence, 20, does not remember his childhood days—he was dumped on Bangalore's streets as a three-year-old till he was rescued by the nuns of a Catholic congregation. And so it was with Vageesh and Anup—also abandoned at a remand home.

Today these youngsters in their orange T-shirts are the owners of an ice-cream parlour and juice centre, Echo-Choco, at Kammanahalli, Bangalore, thanks to the support provided by Empowerment of Children and Human Rights Organisation (Echo)—a non-profit group which also runs a centre for juvenile justice. The parlour is just a month old but people are pitching in with inputs. A well known photographer is helping design a logo while others suggest how they can spice up their menu. "The whole experience is new to us. To feel that we are part of a management team is simply beyond

our imagination. This is our home," says Vageesh.

The parlour started with help from Echo's supporters, a bank loan, and operates out of a rented house. The idea is to make it self-reliant and plough the money back into youth welfare programmes. Families patronise the parlour because of the good cause associated with it. "We decided to celebrate our daughter's birthday here instead of a well-known brand," says S. Joseph, a medical doctor.

"Most of the boys working at Echo-Choco are underprivileged youngsters with a background of poverty and history of conflict with the law," says Echo founder-director Father Anthony Sebastian. "Our job is to empower them so that they will in turn help other youngsters who are in dire straits. Not just hand-outs but a leg up so they can stand on their own feet." Echo has also trained hundreds of young boys to become traffic police assistants with the help of the Bangalore Police. Majid sums up his experience: "Earlier, the environment was one of petty crime but now it is about ownership and a new lease of life."